SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #1 · FAMILY TRADITIONS AND HERITAGE

“We don't talk about our problems outside the family.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Many families, cultures, and churches prize privacy. Some of that is wise: not every struggle belongs on social media. But when the rule hardens into “never tell anyone,” abuse, addiction, depression, and money trouble can go unaddressed for years. Children learn to keep secrets, and adults carry hurts alone because speaking up feels like betrayal.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture honors both discretion and honesty. Paul writes, “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ.” James says, “Confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed.” Proverbs says, “He who conceals his sins will not prosper, but whoever confesses and renounces them will find mercy.” And “Open your mouth for those with no voice.” Wisdom chooses whom to tell and how, but secrecy that keeps people suffering or in danger is not what God asks of a family.

> *“Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ”* (Galatians 6:2).

Also see

> “Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous man has great power to prevail” (James 5:16).

> “He who conceals his sins will not prosper, but whoever confesses and renounces them will find mercy” (Proverbs 28:13).

> “Open your mouth for those with no voice, for the cause of all the dispossessed. Open your mouth, judge righteously, and defend the cause of the poor and needy” (Proverbs 31:8–9).

> “But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus His Son cleanses us from all sin” (1 John 1:7).

Common self-statements

- What happens at home stays at home.
- Talking about it would shame us.
- Strong families handle things privately.
- No one outside could understand.
- If I tell, I am betraying them.
- We just do not speak about that.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must tell everyone or no one.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should never share family struggles.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining that telling anyone will destroy the family.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling disloyal and concluding that I am.

Challenging questions

- Where did I learn this rule, and what was it meant to protect?
- What has silence cost me and my family?
- Who is a wise, trustworthy person I could talk with?
- What is the difference between privacy and secrecy?
- Is anyone in danger because we are keeping quiet?
- What does Scripture say about bearing burdens together?

Truth summary

> Healthy privacy is wise, but silence that keeps people hurting is not. I can share my burdens with trustworthy people, seek help for my family, and still honor those I love. If anyone is in danger, speaking up is the loving thing to do.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Confession
- Communication
- Church
- Help
- Friendship

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Communication
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "We don't talk about our problems outside the family"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"We don't talk about our problems outside the family." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is the rule in my family?
- ☐ What has silence cost?
- ☐ Who is safe?
- ☐ What is privacy and what is secrecy?
- ☐ Is anyone in danger?
- ☐ What will I share first?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ We are meant to carry burdens together.
- ☐ Confession and prayer lead to healing.
- ☐ Privacy and secrecy are not the same.
- ☐ Speaking up can be an act of love.
- ☐ I can choose wise, safe people.
- ☐ Light brings healing.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Galatians 6:2
  "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."
- ☐ James 5:16
  "Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous man has great power to prevail."
- ☐ Proverbs 28:13
  "He who conceals his sins will not prosper, but whoever confesses and renounces them will find mercy."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] One honest conversation: Each week, note one honest conversation with a safe person and what you learned.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Galatians 6:2 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can carry burdens with others and still honor my family.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Confession" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the rule. Write the unspoken rule and who taught it.
- [ ] Pick a safe person. Choose a pastor, counselor, or trusted friend.
- [ ] Share one thing. Tell them part of the story and see how it goes.
- [ ] Get help if anyone is unsafe. If someone is in danger, call 911 or the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "We don't talk about our problems outside the family": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	An honest conversation
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~We don't talk about our problems outside the family.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, my family taught me to keep quiet. Give me wisdom about whom to trust, courage to speak, and healing as I carry burdens with others. Protect those I love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #2 · FAMILY TRADITIONS AND HERITAGE

"Asking for help is a sign of weakness."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Families and cultures that prize self-reliance, whether through farm life, immigrant struggle, military service, or hard times, often teach that needing help is shameful. Children who watched parents never ask learn to white-knuckle through illness, money problems, and sorrow alone.

What Scripture teaches

Solomon observes, "Two are better than one… For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!" Paul says that the parts of the body that seem weaker are indispensable, and tells us to "carry one another's burdens." Moses needed Aaron and Hur to hold up his arms, and Jesus Himself was helped by Simon of Cyrene. The psalmist prays, "You are my helper and deliverer." God designed us to need Him and each other. Asking for help is wisdom, not weakness.

> *"Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!"* (Ecclesiastes 4:9–10).

Also see

> "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ" (Galatians 6:2).

> "On the contrary, the parts of the body that seem to be weaker are indispensable" (1 Corinthians 12:22).

> "But I am poor and needy; may the Lord think of me. You are my helper and deliverer; O my God, do not delay" (Psalm 40:17).

> "Plans fail for lack of counsel, but with many advisers they succeed" (Proverbs 15:22).

Common self-statements

- Real adults handle things alone.
- If I ask, I look weak.
- We never needed anyone.
- I do not want to be a burden.
- Asking means I have failed.
- I should be able to manage.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I should never need help.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing myself as either strong or needy.
- Mind reading: Assuming others will think less of me.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling embarrassed and concluding that asking is wrong.

Challenging questions

- Who in my family never asked for help, and what did it cost them?

- How do I feel about someone who asks me for help?
- What does Scripture say about the strength of a body made of many parts?
- What am I struggling with alone right now?
- What is one small request I could make?
- What would it be like to let someone help?

Truth summary

> Needing help is part of how God made me. Asking is wise, humble, and strong, and it lets others use their gifts. I can ask for help and receive it with thanks.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Help
- Humility
- Pride
- Friendship
- Weakness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Pride
- Weak/Tired

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God's faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

Oh My Soul — Casting Crowns
Honest distress can coexist with faith and hope in God.

What a Friend We Have in Jesus — Keith and Kristyn Getty
This classic hymn invites direct, honest prayer with the Savior who carries our burdens.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Asking for help is a sign of weakness"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Asking for help is a sign of weakness." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who never asked in my family?
- ☐ What do I carry alone?
- ☐ How do I see people who ask?
- ☐ What can I request?
- ☐ Who can help?
- ☐ How will I thank them?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Two are better than one.
- ☐ The weaker parts are indispensable.
- ☐ God is my helper.
- ☐ Asking is wisdom.
- ☐ Receiving lets others give.
- ☐ I was not made to do life alone.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Ecclesiastes 4:9–10
  "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!"
- ☐ Galatians 6:2
  "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."
- ☐ Psalm 40:17
  "But I am poor and needy; may the Lord think of me. You are my helper and deliverer; O my God, do not delay."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] A request made: Each week, note one request for help and how it went.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Ecclesiastes 4:9–10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Two are better than one, so I can ask for help.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Help" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] List what you carry alone. Write the tasks and worries you handle by yourself.
- [ ] Ask for one thing. Make a small, specific request.
- [ ] Say thank you. Receive help without apology.
- [ ] Help someone. Notice how it feels to be asked.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Asking for help is a sign of weakness": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A request made
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Asking for help is a sign of weakness.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You made me to need You and others. Help me ask without shame and receive with gratitude. Thank You for those You send to help. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #3 · FAMILY TRADITIONS AND HERITAGE

"I must never bring shame on my family."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

In many cultures, family honor is central. A child's failure, divorce, pregnancy, addiction, or leaving the family's faith or traditions can be treated as a stain on everyone. Children grow up scanning for what might disgrace the family, and adults may carry heavy fear of disappointing parents and relatives.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture teaches honor for parents: "Honor your father and mother." It also teaches that each person stands before God: "Each of us will give an account of himself to God," and "The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son." Isaiah promises, "Do not be afraid, for you will not be put to shame." Our shame is not the family's verdict on us. Christ bore it. Honor is a way of treating our family with love, not a requirement to be flawless.

> *"So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God"* (Romans 14:12).

Also see

> "Honor your father and mother, so that your days may be long in the land that the LORD your God is giving you" (Exodus 20:12).

> "Yet you may ask, 'Why shouldn't the son bear the iniquity of his father?' Since the son has done what is just and right, carefully observing all My statutes, he will surely live. The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him" (Ezekiel 18:19–20).

> "Do not be afraid, for you will not be put to shame; do not be intimidated, for you will not be humiliated. For you will forget the shame of your youth and will remember no more the reproach of your widowhood" (Isaiah 54:4).

> "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1).

Common self-statements

- If I fail, my whole family is disgraced.
- I cannot let them down.
- People will talk about us.
- I have to keep up appearances.
- My mistake is everyone's mistake.
- I carry the family name.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Believing my choices determine my family's worth.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining total disgrace from a mistake.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must never fail.
- Mind reading: Assuming I know what relatives and neighbors think.

Challenging questions

- What exactly would count as bringing shame in my family?
- Who set that standard, and who benefits from it?
- Is a family's honor the same as perfection?
- What does Scripture say about each person answering for their own choices?
- What would honoring my family look like without hiding who I am?
- What can I do with real mistakes: confess, repair, learn?

Truth summary

> Honoring my family does not require perfection or hiding. Each of us answers to God for our own choices, and Christ has taken my shame. I can honor those I love with respect and honesty and trust God with what others think.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Pride
- Parenting
- Obedience
- Self-Esteem, Low

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Parenting

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Clean — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must never bring shame on my family"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must never bring shame on my family." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What counts as shame in my family?
- ☐ Who set the standard?
- ☐ What does honor look like?
- ☐ What is mine to answer for?
- ☐ What would I confess or repair?
- ☐ Who can I talk to?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Each person answers to God for their own choices.
- ☐ I can honor my parents without being perfect.
- ☐ I will not be put to shame in Christ.
- ☐ There is no condemnation for me.
- ☐ Honesty can honor my family.
- ☐ God, not gossip, defines me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Romans 14:12**
  "So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God."
- ☐ **Isaiah 54:4**
  "Do not be afraid, for you will not be put to shame; do not be intimidated, for you will not be humiliated. For you will forget the shame of your youth and will remember no more the reproach of your widowhood."
- ☐ **Romans 8:1**
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Honor without hiding: Each week, note one way you honored family while being honest.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 14:12 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Each of us answers to God, and in Christ I am not put to shame.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Define shame. Write what your family counts as shameful.
- [ ] Test each one. Ask whether it is biblical, cultural, or personal opinion.
- [ ] Honor in a real way. Do one respectful act toward a family member.
- [ ] Talk with someone safe. Share your fear with a trusted counselor or pastor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must never bring shame on my family": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Honor without hiding
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must never bring shame on my family.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I fear disappointing my family. Free me from shame, teach me to honor them with love, and help me live honestly before You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #4 · FAMILY TRADITIONS AND HERITAGE

“Our family has always been this way, and it can't change.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Patterns such as anger, addiction, divorce, poverty, silence, or distance can run for generations, and people often say, “That is just how we are.” Hearing it repeated can make change feel disloyal or impossible.

What Scripture teaches

God told Israel through Ezekiel that the proverb about sins passing to the next generation would no longer be used, and said, “A son will not bear the iniquity of his father.” Paul writes, “If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” God promises, “I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you.” Patterns do shape us, but they are not destiny. One person who changes can begin a new pattern for those who follow.

> *“Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!”* (2 Corinthians 5:17).

Also see

> “Yet you may ask, ‘Why shouldn’t the son bear the iniquity of his father?’ Since the son has done what is just and right, carefully observing all My statutes, he will surely live. The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him” (Ezekiel 18:19–20).

> “I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; I will remove your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh” (Ezekiel 36:26).

> “‘Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.’” (Isaiah 43:18–19).

> “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God” (Romans 12:2).

Common self-statements

- This is how we are.
- It runs in the family.
- We have never done it differently.
- Trying to change is pointless.
- I will end up like them.
- Change would betray the family.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that nothing can change.
- Labeling: Treating “our family” as a fixed identity.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either conform or leave.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling stuck and concluding that I am.

Challenging questions

- Which patterns in my family do I want to keep, and which do I want to change?
- Has anyone in my family broken a pattern, even partly?
- What would a first small change look like?
- What does it mean to be a new creation?
- Who could support me in changing?
- What would I want my children or the next generation to say about me?

Truth summary

> Family patterns are real, but they are not destiny. In Christ I am a new creation, and God gives me a new heart. I can keep what is good, change what is harmful, and begin a better pattern.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Born Again
- Sinful Nature
- Parenting
- Thinking, Unhealthy
- Holy Spirit

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Parenting

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Chain Breaker — Zach Williams
Christ offers rescue and freedom to people who feel trapped by their past.

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Our family has always been this way, and it can't change"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Our family has always been this way, and it can't change." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What patterns do I see?
- ☐ What do I want to keep?
- ☐ Who broke a pattern?
- ☐ What first step?
- ☐ Who supports me?
- ☐ What do I hope for the next generation?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am a new creation in Christ.
- ☐ God gives me a new heart.
- ☐ Patterns are not destiny.
- ☐ I can keep the good and change the harmful.
- ☐ Each person answers for their own choices.
- ☐ A new pattern can begin with me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 2 Corinthians 5:17
  "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!"
- ☐ Ezekiel 36:26
  "I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; I will remove your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh."
- ☐ Ezekiel 18:19–20
  "Yet you may ask, 'Why shouldn't the son bear the iniquity of his father?' Since the son has done what is just and right, carefully observing all My statutes, he will surely live. The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] A new pattern: Each week, note one thing you did differently from the old pattern.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 2 Corinthians 5:17 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am a new creation in Christ, not a copy of the past.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Born Again" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] List the patterns. Write what to keep and what to change.
- [ ] Pick one change. Choose a small, specific change.
- [ ] Get support. Tell a pastor or friend what you are trying.
- [ ] Repair quickly. When you slip, apologize and begin again.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Our family has always been this way, and it can't change": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A new pattern
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Our family has always been this way, and it can't change.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, change begins with You. Give me a new heart, show me what to keep and what to leave, and make me the beginning of something healthier for my family. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #5 · FAMILY TRADITIONS AND HERITAGE

"I have to live up to what my family expects of me."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Families often have unspoken scripts about career, marriage, faith, location, and success. A child may be told, openly or not, what they will be: a doctor, a farmer, a pastor, a parent. Falling short or choosing another road can feel like betrayal and bring guilt, conflict, or silence.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God?" and "Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind." Jeremiah says of God, "I know the plans I have for you." Each person has gifts: "God has arranged the members of the body, every one of them, according to His design." Scripture also says to honor your father and mother. Honor is respect and care. It does not require giving up the calling and life God gives you.

> *"Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ"* (Galatians 1:10).

Also see

> "Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God" (Romans 12:2).

> "For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope" (Jeremiah 29:11).

> "But in fact, God has arranged the members of the body, every one of them, according to His design" (1 Corinthians 12:18).

> "Honor your father and mother, so that your days may be long in the land that the LORD your God is giving you" (Exodus 20:12).

Common self-statements

- I owe them the life they planned for me.
- If I choose differently, I am betraying them.
- I cannot disappoint my parents.
- Their approval is worth more than my own path.
- I must meet their expectations.
- My dreams do not matter.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I must fulfill others' plans.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty about my choices and concluding that they are wrong.
- Mind reading: Assuming I know how my family will react.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either obey completely or betray.

Challenging questions

- What exactly does my family expect, and where did that come from?
- Which expectations fit who God made me to be, and which do not?
- What are my gifts, and what do I sense God calling me toward?
- How could I honor my family while choosing my own path?
- What would I regret if I spent my life meeting expectations?
- Who could help me talk with my family?

Truth summary

> I can honor my family without living their plan for me. God has given me my own gifts and calling. I can speak respectfully, listen to their concerns, and follow God's leading with a clear conscience.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Will of God
- Obedience
- Parenting
- Pride
- Guidance

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Communication

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Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I have to live up to what my family expects of me"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

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Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to live up to what my family expects of me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does my family expect?
- ☐ Which fit me?
- ☐ What is God calling me toward?
- ☐ How can I honor them?
- ☐ What will I say?
- ☐ Who can help?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I seek God's approval first.
- ☐ God has plans for me.
- ☐ He arranged me according to His design.
- ☐ I can honor without obeying every expectation.
- ☐ My calling is mine to discern.
- ☐ I can speak respectfully and stand firm.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- ☐ **Romans 12:2**
  "Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God."
- ☐ **Jeremiah 29:11**
  "For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

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  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] My path and my honor: Each week, note one choice made prayerfully and one act of honor toward family.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Galatians 1:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I seek God's approval first and honor my family with love.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Will of God" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Write the expectations. List what your family expects and which you hold yourself.
- [ ] Sort them. Mark which fit you and which do not.
- [ ] Pray about your calling. Ask God what He has for you.
- [ ] Plan a respectful conversation. Prepare what you will say, with kindness.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to live up to what my family expects of me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to live up to what my family expects of me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I want to honor my family and follow You. Show me what You have called me to, give me wisdom to speak with respect, and free me from living for others' approval. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.